Hindu, to begin with? Bhagwat specifically addressed these questions in his annual Vijayadashami address of 2018: 'Those sections of the society who consider themselves "separate" because of their religion, tradition and lifestyle or [are] apprehensive of the word "Hindu" need to understand that Hindutva is the eternal ethos of this country. Hindutva has intrinsic identification with the undivided land of Bharat from the Himalayas up to the seas. All the Bharatiyas should immerse themselves in the hue of Bharat's culture ingrained in its ethos is a sincere wish of the Sangh. The practices of all the sects and traditions of Bharat derive themselves from this cultural ethos … Hindutva is behind Bharat's capacity to embrace the entire universe with acceptance and appreciation of all its distinct diversities.' That is why, he concluded, 'Bharat is the Hindu Rashtra.'[36]

The Place of Muslims and Christians in the Hindu Rashtra

The big question is whether Muslims and Christians—the two religions with their 'birthplaces' outside India—have any place in this cultural Hindu Rashtra? The RSS is at pains to insist that they do. Mohan Bhagwat declared in Delhi in 2018 that 'Hindu Rashtra does not mean that it has no place for Muslims. The day it is said that Muslims are unwanted here, the concept of Hindutva will cease to be.'[37] But the real question is this: will Muslims have a place of equality with Hindus in the Hindu Rashtra? What sort of Muslims are acceptable in this world view? To understand this, one must go back to the argument that the BJP often made during the height of the Ram Janmabhoomi movement, for Muslims to accept Ram as a 'Imam-e-Hind' and to give Hindus cultural primacy.

The BJP's late K.R. Malkani said in 1992: 'The Hindu has no intention of going theocratic and setting up a Hindu State … The Hindu is secular by conviction. He believes in pluralism … The Indian Union is one only because it is Hindu from the Himalayas to the Seas, and from Gujarat to Bengal. And it will remain one only if its Hindu character is recognised, not eroded. This does not mean that the non-Hindu will have fewer rights; but it does mean that the basic character of India shall not be challenged in the name of